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Ken Peplowski

Tenor saxophonist/clarinetist Ken Peplowski is one of the younger generation of jazz musicians who excels in the small group swing genre. He was born in Cleveland on May 23, 1959, and began playing professionally while still in his teens. Ken played with the Tommy Dorsey Orchestra, led by Buddy Morrow, and soon after with Benny Goodman's last big band. He has recorded frequently on the Concord label, often with vocalists Rosemary Clooney and Mel Torme. Howard Alden is a favorite bandmate and the two appear in Ken's video "The Ken Peplowski Quintet with Harry 'Sweets' Edison."

Ken was interviewed at the Jerome Jazz Party in Aspen, Colorado on October 10, 1997, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today in Aspen, Colorado, and it's a great pleasure for me to welcome Ken Peplowski, clarinetist and tenor saxophonist.

KP: Glad to be here.

MR: This kind of seems like heaven here to me. I mean you get invited to play jazz with some great musicians in this beautiful surrounding. How did you manage that?

KP: How did I manage it? I picked up the phone.

MR: Did you really?

KP: Well I mean there's obvious plusses and minuses to this. It sounds like a great, glamorous life to people that don't do it. But it's not as easy as it sounds. I mean this is a luxury to be in a place for even four or five days like this, and not have to travel a lot. When I do my own tours, in fact I have one coming up in Spain, and it's going to be all one-nighters, sometimes playing with local rhythm sections, which you're never sure about, and it's a lot of hard traveling and then you have to show up to the job and play as if you're incredibly happy to be there playing with this fine band. Because the audience doesn't know about that stuff, nor should they.

MR: Right. If you were to tell them that boy it sure was hard getting here today, what's the difference to them?

KP: Yeah. And there's a friend of mine, Warren Vache, who said it's not the traveling — we don't get paid for the music, we get paid for the traveling. And that's really what it's all about because the music makes it worth while, as cliché as that sounds, there's no other reason why we would do something like this.

MR: When you're in Spain, you get with this local band, and you have a repertoire of tunes that you know, and that you hope that they know, do you get a little talk-through rehearsal with them beforehand?

KP: Sometimes yes, sometimes no. I've had to just go right to the job and we have got five minutes. And you really learn how to quickly make decisions. For example there's common tunes that everybody should know. And if they don't know those tunes, you're really in trouble. Like "I Got Rhythm" changes, certain blues, things like that, standards that are really considered across the board standards, like "Lady Be Good." So if you don't know these guys you first try a song like that and see how they are. Then you might try throwing some music at them and see if they can read. But those kind of jobs you're kind of learning as you go. But I usually travel with a book of my things and some easier things that they could play if it's not a great band, and I'll try to meet them halfway. I mean obviously I love to work with my own band and I try to do that as much as I can, but a lot of times they just don't have the kind of money to bring everybody over.

MR: So being able to deal with those kind of situations is almost as important as the kind of player you are, because even if you're a great player, you have to have the ability to be flexible.

KP: You do. And you have to have the ability to not let things phase you that easily. I really learned from a master of that kind of thing, Sonny Stitt, the great saxophone player. I studied with him, I used to watch him play all the time. He did that his whole life. He just traveled around and played with local rhythm sections. And he learned to have a certain consistency in his playing no matter what else was going on behind him. And there's a talent to that. It teaches you a discipline as a musician. If you can find guys that you're really sympathetic with on the bandstand, or women, and you can hook up with them, that's great. But you also have to learn to block out the bad influences and sometimes you're literally just playing for yourself. And then even after the end of what seemed like a not-so-good night, you can at least say that you played good or you did the best you could. And then maybe the audience can hear a little bit of that.

MR: Do you book your own things into Spain, and those kind of tours?

KP: It's a combination of booking my own things, and I've got agents in different parts of the world. I've had a long lost search for a manager and it always ends in disaster. It's very hard to find somebody that is trustworthy and that has the time to devote and that. I've had some experiences with managers in the past where after six months to a year you're looking back at the year and you say well I've just paid this person a lot of money for things that I could have done myself. So I wind up taking everything back on again myself. It's a lot of work though, because I can spend as much or more time on the business end as the playing end, which you really don't want to do. But it's a never ending search. But I do have agents in England and I have got a guy in Spain, and the record company that I'm with, Concord, sometimes people just call up the company trying to get ahold of me. So it's kind of a combination of the phone ringing, which was

the case with this festival. Ralph Sutton has been a friend of mine and we've played together a lot so that's the connection there. And me getting out and trying to hustle jobs. Like I'll do mailings to colleges or orchestras, I'm doing pops concerts now and things like that.

MR: Never ending.

KP: Yeah it is never ending.

MR: As soon as you slack off you're going to notice it I would imagine.

KP: Yeah. That's the one thing that is never, it's not a nice thing about this business. There's always a sense of insecurity, job insecurity. Because you may have, like we're talking now in October, and I'm already booked into next November, a year from November. But then you start worrying about after that. Immediately. So the thing is you have to learn, again it's a discipline and it's always a learning lesson. You need to learn not to let that stuff get to the playing side, and not to worry about what everybody else is doing or not doing, and just try to be yourself and play the best you can. And there's a niche for everybody.

MR: I'm glad you brought that up. The niche. You're at the age where when you were growing up you could have latched on to some of the more contemporary musicians, and maybe you did, but the music circle that you seem to exist in is more of the mainstream type. What influences did grab on to you?

KP: Well I actually grew up listening to The Beatles at the same time as I was listening to Benny Goodman. And strangely enough my first musical experience was playing in a Polish polka band in Cleveland, Ohio. And that was good training for jazz because that particular kind of music, it's two trumpets playing in tandem and the clarinet improvises around them and you have four or five sections to each song and drum breaks and things like that. So it's not unlike New Orleans jazz, as strange as it sounds. So I learned how to improvise just by doing it. I never took a jazz lesson in my life. But one thing about my family, they were always into all kinds of music and we were encouraged to listen to anything around the house. And back then and to this day I like to listen to all kinds of things. I was a huge Beatles fan and I still am. In fact I collect all these unreleased recordings and everything. And Elvis Costello I like. You know I listen to all kinds of pop music. I even like the music of Ornette Coleman, I've recorded some of his things. The mainstream thing, I just happen to like to interpret other people's songs. Because I don't consider myself a real great composer. So for me the interest lies in finding things that I can try to put my own voice to. You see my name a lot on these kind of jazz parties and things because I play the clarinet and the saxophone, but I do try to branch out a little bit more than that. I did a record in Bulgaria with an orchestra and we did some kind of twentieth century contemporary classical things and an Ornette Coleman piece. And I'm

really trying to show people in a way that there's not that big of a gap between the music of Benny Goodman and the music of Ornette Coleman. It's only a difference of — you know this whole history of jazz takes place, all the major movements, you're talking about at most a 40 or 50 year gap of time.

MR: Yeah. It really strikes me how fast jazz has moved along in its history and sometimes I wonder if it almost isn't too fast.

KP: Yeah, well maybe in a way. But the amazing thing, with all those changes is that people still — musicians and listeners can be very closed minded and say I just like music of the 1930s, I just like to listen to Coltrane and beyond. There's so much out there that you could listen to and love and why limit yourself to one small little gap of time? So I really try to play and listen to as many things as I can. And even if I'm playing an old standard, somehow all these things are filtered into my playing. For me, if I play a song that's written in 1920, I'm not thinking of trying to re-create some old style or play like Benny Goodman or do something like that. This is me, and this is a song I like, and this is what I'm playing, although I loved Benny. And as far as contemporary jazz or Kenny G type stuff, that music I dislike in the same way that I dislike manufactured calculated pop music. It's the same thing. It's almost like it's music made by a committee. It's just boring to me. Electric drums and like the fake soul filigrees that they play on every tune. Some of those kind of groups — I used to love The Crusaders for example, because they were very creative within that kind of music. They were playing together, they were improvising together.

MR: Yeah, in my opinion when a Crusaders tune was done, you could hum the tune back.

KP: Yes.

MR: You know, sometimes when I listen to some of the more contemporary guys, when the tune is over it's like, hmmm, how did that go?

KP: Yeah.

MR: Can't recall.

KP: That's right. In fact Steve Allen, you know the piano player? He was telling me, he was talking about this very thing. And he said, "I defy you to hum back the tune to the new Tonight Show." I can't think of it.

MR: That's true. And you see that in some of the T.V. shows too. You know I bet if I asked you, you could hum the tune to The Dick VanDyke Show.

KP: Of course, all those old things, yeah.

MR: You know, N.Y.P.D. Blue has cool theme but it's not like, hmmm, yeah, oh there's a drum thing and, you know.

KP: Which is exactly the reason why I play other people's songs. Because I am not a composer. And I'm not going to write a bunch of tunes to put on a record just to have

some publishing money. I get bored listening to whole records of other people doing that. So that's my big test for myself. Is this going to bore me?

MR: Well that's a pretty good — what do you call it — litmus test?

KP: Yeah.

MR: If it bores you it's probably going to bore someone else.

KP: Yeah.

MR: How did — your first big job, that you said man, I've been working towards this and this finally happened.

KP: It's kind of a two part thing. When I was living in Cleveland and I was playing of course in this polka band, and at the same time I started branching out and playing with jazz groups around town. Flash forward a few years, I'm in college. I get called to play at a jazz festival in Cleveland with my own group, and it's me, the Teddy Wilson trio and the Tommy Dorsey band — a ghost band — but so anyway so I do this concert and it's a big deal for me. And I got asked to join the Dorsey band that night by the leader, Buddy Morrow, who's still on the band, over 20 years later now. He's like an iron man. He's this great trombone player who is eternally on the road and never practiced a day that I knew and picked up his horn cold and played the theme song, "I'm Getting Sentimental For You," perfectly every night. And that was my big break. That got me out of Cleveland. I took a job on the road with that band. And even though it was a ghost band, at that time it was a really good band, and there were a lot of big bands still around. This was like the late 70s. All the bands were still around — Duke's band and Basie and Buddy Rich, Woody Herman. And we were all in those circles. And that was a big deal for me because in fact my teacher in Cleveland, my clarinet teacher said to me when I was debating whether I should go on this job or not, he said, "look you can be a big fish in a small pond, or you can get out there and challenge yourself." And that's what I decided to do. And I was on that band for about two and a half years. A great time, a lot of hard work. We were traveling 48 weeks out of the year.

MR: Mostly bus work?

KP: Mostly bus, oh, you know like we'd play the job, we'd do what we call "hit and runs." We'd play the job, get on the bus twelve hours, next place. And then you get to the next town and we're paying for our own rooms too.

MR: No kidding.

KP: Speaking of the glamorous life. So we'd do what we call "ghosting," where you'd have one guy check in with a single, and then two others would sneak in the back way. You know and you'd make bets and whoever lost the bet would sleep on the floor that night. And there was one guy who I won't name who decided to stay on the bus for about a

year, and he got a little weird as time went on. You could imagine. His friends the dust mites and—

MR: Oh my.

KP: Yeah it gets a little strange.

MR: He probably smelled like a bus for about a year.

KP: Well I mean he'd borrow somebody's shower for a day every once in a while. But when you're in your early 20s it's fun. Now it's not. And we saw the world, we traveled around, all the big life experiences you get on this thing. Learned how to play cards, and other things that I won't mention now, but it was a good time and also a real discipline musically. Because I was playing lead alto, and he gave me like a spotlight within the concerts of 15 minutes to just do my own thing on clarinet. He was so nice to me. In fact when I decided to leave the band I was really torn about this. He told me he said, "look you're not going to learn any more here, you should go to New York." He made a bunch of phone calls for me. He even tried to set up, they were just forming the Artie Shaw band again, and he set up an interview with the Willard Alexander Agency for me to be the band leader, see they were looking for a clarinet player. But they — you know we never heard of this guy he's too young. But it was nice of him to even think of this.

MR: Who did they get for that?

KP: Dick Johnson.

MR: I'm not familiar with him.

KP: He lives in Boston. In fact the ironic thing is Dick used to play in Buddy Morrow's band in the early 1950s. And Dick is a wonderful clarinet player and a very nice guy too. And he's a man you might want to talk to, he's an interesting guy. But he did a lot for me. So that was my big job experience. And then moving to New York after that, you know I was scared to death. I didn't know anybody and I was there about six months before I even got any work. Oh in between that I did eight months on the road with "Annie," just to make some money. And I have to tell you, this show, about the little kid and the orphans and the Christmas tree and the dog, this was the wildest time I've ever had in my entire life. Because the music was so boring and the mothers were traveling with the kids and it was unbelievable. I've never experienced anything like this in rock circles, in jazz circles, a constant party going on, everybody sleeping with everybody else, the mothers were having affairs with the musicians, I mean it was unbelievable. And so I did eight months and then I thought, I'd better get out of here because I'm going to wind up, you know.

MR: Like this show is so squeaky clean, we're going to go the other way.

KP: Exactly. I could write a book, and maybe I will some day, about that time I had on that show.

MR: That's wild.

KP: It is wild, really. So I left after eight months and came to New York, and not a penny was saved incidentally in that time. So that was a disaster.

MR: So much for that.

KP: Yeah. So I came to New York, knew no one, I was there for six months — in fact I moved to New York with the hairdresser from the show. This tells you what a crazy thing it was, subletting an apartment from an actress who I'd had an affair with and then her husband found out about it.

MR: This plot is thickening.

KP: Yeah. And then I wound up having to move out of that apartment. That's a whole other story, well we don't have to get into that story, but so anyway, so six months nothing. No work. I was ready to take a day job. I'd never worked, in fact I never have — knock on wood — never have done anything but music my whole life, since I was ten. So this was really depressing for me. And I actually talked my way into a job with a photo, one of these photo processing labs, Gene Berry Photos, as the Assistant Manager. And I knew nothing about photos, nothing about being an Assistant Manager. So I was ready to show up for work on Monday morning. I got up, I just thought about this. I called the guy and said "I know you're not going to understand this, but I can't do this job." And I just hung in there for another few weeks. I started getting calls to sub on other bands. This is what happens in New York. You have to stay there long enough to get your name around, and you have to do as many circles of jobs as you can before you find what it is that you want to do. So you wind up subbing for a lot of musicians, big bands, Latin bands, weddings, anything. In fact I remember playing a wedding pretty soon after I moved to New York with Buddy Tate on saxophone, Mel Lewis on drums and Steve Kuhn on piano.

MR: No kidding.

KP: Yes. And I thought to myself, geez, either the weddings here are really great or the musicians are scuffling a little more than I would like. And it's kind of in between the two.

MR: Yeah. I mean those guys, that particular gig, were they playing the standard wedding stuff?

KP: No. See in New York there are more jazz-oriented weddings. Like people will hire a jazz band in New York like they would hire a string quartet because they want to have some class for an evening. Although there's countless numbers of stories where you go in telling these people, this is all we do, this is what we play, and then you get there and they want to hear —

MR: They want to hear "Celebration."

KP: Yeah. That's the tune all right. And "New York New York" you know and stuff like that. But I think on that job they left them alone though. That was a kind of a nice job. But I couldn't believe that. It's really surprising around New York, the people you run into in the most unexpected places. But that's the beauty of it too because you keep meeting new faces and new musical circles. There's all these little groups around New York that do different things. And one guy plays not only in this group of people but in this group, so there's the connection. So in fact the bass player I have in my band now, Greg Cohen, plays with John Zorn's band also. I don't know if you're —

MR: Yeah.

KP: So I've been talking a lot to some of those guys. In fact I'm talking to this clarinet player Marty Ehrlich about doing some recording together and trying to find a common bond. I love doing that. It's a challenge for me because I like their music a lot and it's good sometimes to test myself and see what I can bring to that kind of music. So anyway, when I first moved to New York that also was a huge big experience for me. And there's a few highlights like that I could talk about. Working with Benny Goodman, of course playing the clarinet, he was a big idol for me.

MR: You played tenor with him?

KP: I played tenor with him. But I'd given him some tapes of me playing clarinet and he never said a word about these. However I found out after he died from the president of the record company that he was with at the end, Music Masters, that he wanted them to sign me up and he would produce a record for me. But they didn't — well we never heard of this guy you know — and then I went with Concord and I'm playing a job and the president of the record company shows up and he says, "I just wanted to tell you we could kick ourselves because Benny really wanted us to record you." And I knew nothing about this until after he died.

MR: He was pretty tight-lipped.

KP: He was a tight-lipped guy. He's not the evil person that you've heard in a lot of books or interviews. He was a complex guy. I think he really didn't know how to deal with his fame. He was uncomfortable about it and I think almost his whole life revolved around music, to the exclusion, unfortunately, of thinking about people's feelings and things like that. But he just was obsessed with music. He practiced all the time. He was always thinking about those old Fletcher Henderson charts, how can I play them and make them sound fresh. And he did too. At the end we had a great band. But I think he was a very lonely guy. And I got pretty close to him at the end. We would go out to lunch all the time and I still have some phone messages from him and letters and things like that. I miss him, I do. The last band that was with him I think he had genuine affection for and we had affection for him. We respected him and we were there trying to play his music

the way he wanted it and I think he liked that. He was a very tough band leader though. We could go through a whole rehearsal and not get past the first eight bars of a tune. Very tough, very demanding, but he got results. And he whipped us into shape and made us sound like a Benny Goodman band. He was no more tough or crazy than Buddy Rich for example.

MR: What was in his instructions that made you sound like a Benny Goodman band?

KP: Well one big thing with him was everybody had to develop their own strong sense of time, of rhythm. One thing that they've talked about in books and I've experienced this first-hand, he would rehearse the wind players without the rhythm section and sometimes he would start a tune with everybody and then cut the rhythm section out and we'd have to play on our own, swinging, as if the rhythm section was there. And I learned that that's the way he played. He had such strong time that he could actually bring up a bad rhythm section or a bad band. A very strong sense of time. It's the kind of thing that you can't even write it down. You can't put it in a textbook. You'd have to experience it first hand. But you realize when you're on your own, if you're not like self-propelling, if you're not moving the music forward, then things start dragging or it sounds like a band just playing dots on a piece of paper. And he got us to swing. He got us to play on our own with this internal rhythm. Then when everybody comes together it swings like you can't believe. And it's all about listening and as soon as you start a tempo that's when the time begins. And it was an amazing thing. I've never experienced anybody before or since that could rehearse a band like him. And it was a real lesson for me. And also this old frail man would still get up and play these tunes that he'd been playing over and over and over and sound like he'd been playing them for the first time. There were nights when he just blew us off the stage. We did a night at Radio City Music Hall and it was a fund raiser. It was Ella Fitzgerald, Placido Domingo, Sinatra and Benny. So he was, he knew he was in tough company there. And Sinatra was even in the wings watching us. Benny played so good that night, this was a night to remember for me, he played so good we missed all of our entrances. We couldn't even play, literally. We were just sitting there listening to this guy. I remember "Stealing Apples" that famous Fletcher Henderson thing, chorus after chorus after chorus and we were just dumbfounded. Like something just turned on in him. Louie Bellson was playing drums and even he said, "geez I haven't heard him play like this since the 40s."

MR: Wow. It almost sounds like the story I've heard about when Charlie Christian was introduced on the bandstand that particular night and he just was inspired to play even beyond himself.

KP: Yeah. But that's the thing. You know if you're going to play music, if you've made this commitment, the worst thing you can do for yourself is treat it like a job and show up —

like these kind of things — we're on a jazz party right now. It's very easy to just go and play the same old tunes. And a lot of people do, to be honest, and get very lazy about it. But it's not worth my while personally to get up there and just go through the motions. Even if I'm playing somebody else's same old tune, I'm trying to play some music, for good or for bad. I'm not saying I'm a great musician but at least I try. Otherwise there's no point to playing music. You could be doing something else and making a lot more money and having a bigger reward and you learn that by being around people like him. Up to the end he was practicing, he was still excited about playing "Stealing Apples" you know, and it meant a lot to him. It was never a nostalgic trip with him. In fact he would get very angry if people wanted to talk about the good old days with Harry James and Gene Krupa. He'd say, "hey I don't want to talk about them, I want to talk about the band I have now."

MR: Well that's great to hear, I'm glad you brought all that up. At these jazz parties, the audience we see at them seems to be, I see a lot of the same people, and I guess they're pretty knowledgeable about the music. It seems to be somewhat of a social event, but they seem to be pretty knowledgeable about the music.

KP: They are pretty knowledgeable, yeah. They tend to be a little bit conservative in their musical taste but if you accept the job you have to kind of play within those parameters. They're not going to want to hear even Thelonious — you know like "Ugly Beauty" or something, or an Ornette Coleman tune. Although once in a while if I get in a set with Howard, Howard Alden or somebody like that, a sympathetic ear or a sympathetic musician, we will throw something at them like that, and cover it up with a bunch of tunes that they know. And then they see maybe it's not too far apart, these two different things. But yeah it's an older, kind of conservative audience, but they are knowledgeable and they love this music and they're very devoted obviously because these people fly around from one city to another. And it's odd in fact, because you do see the same faces.

MR: The first time we went to one I hadn't even heard that these things existed and I was just, at first I was so impressed. I mean you could overhear people having conversations about this guy's latest record and who was in the rhythm section and I'm looking at these people you know — this couple is 60 years old and they're into this that much. And it's great.

KP: It is great.

MR: I don't know how long it will last.

KP: Well there's less and less of these. Because it's an older audience. Frankly they're dying off. And it's always been, they've been proud of the fact that it's a closed circle of people. It costs a fair bit of money to be here for the weekend. Everybody stays at the same hotel. So it's kind of exclusionary. If somebody lives in town for example and just

wants to come in for one night, most of these jazz parties won't even allow them to buy a ticket for a night. In fact I've been really bucking to get them to change that. Or if they're undersold, why not go to the local high school or college and give away a table to the best students or something, and get them to come in. It doesn't cost anything. But it's hard to get them to do that. Because it is a party, it's their thing, so I think this particular thing may not last much longer. But there's always new venues. There's always individual people that like the music enough that they decide to put on concerts because nobody else will. There's a lot of that in Europe. I do tours through England and Germany for example. We play small towns where you would never expect this music to be heard. And it's always one person, just like these jazz parties, there's always like one person who loves the music so much that they want to present it to everybody else. So you can build up a nice tour of 30 dates or so, that are all these small little jazz societies.

MR: Are you enough of a let's say business person that you're able to look at a tour and figure here's what I'm going to gross, how much is it going to cost me for everything else, and then go ahead and do it?

KP: Yeah. I am now more and more. I mean my goal — this may sound like I'm just going for the money but it's not really — I want to work less and be paid more. Because I want to be more and more controlling of the kind of music that I play. And it's gradually reaching that stage. I'll play festivals in Europe where they have enough money to bring over the whole band. And then once you can get everybody over there, on the festival's plane ticket for example, you can do smaller dates with those guys. And you lose a little bit of money yourself. I'd rather make a little bit less and have the music completely the way I want it. So it's always a give and take. Or I'll use, I can do a pops concert or something and make quite a bit of money and then funnel that into sending out a bunch of promotional things to get more jobs for the group. As long as you're still ahead, you're doing okay. And my wife is very supportive of all this too you know. She says look as long as we're eating and living, you do what you want to do.

MR: Do you have kids?

KP: Not yet, no. Actually this is my second marriage. So this time around I'm going to have some kids yeah. My wife is from Sweden. I met her on a job over there.

MR: No kidding.

KP: Yeah. We're going to get a place there, keep a place in New York, and probably raise the kids in Sweden because it's an easier place to do that. But yeah you have to be kind of business savvy. Because it's a constant game, too. It's one of the only jobs, maybe you'll tell me that yours is like this, I don't know, but it's one of the only jobs where every single time you agree to do something, they're trying to negotiate down and you're trying

to go up. Always haggling. It's a constant game of how much you can get, how much they're prepared to pay.

MR: Right. It seems like every particular job always requires, in addition to the back and forth with the money, there's always something a little bit different about every job. How much room do we have on stage? What are the acoustics like? It's never like when a person goes to work every single day, knows what his office is like, and he knows who he's going to be dealing with every day for the most part.

KP: That's right. And the monetary scales are so sliding. You can't even believe it. When people ask, you know I'll do a college workshop and they ask questions like well how much do you make and things like that, it's really hard to tell somebody. Because you can play in New York and you make a hundred dollars at a club. You play a concert you make a few thousand. And somewhere at the end it all balances out to a pretty nice living. But it's never constant, and you always have to make these decisions. Like you make monetary decisions and you make career decisions. For example the Spain trip, they don't have that much money over there. I'm not making huge tons of money, but I don't play Spain often enough that I should pass on it. So it's been a few years since I've been there, I like being there and I feel like I need to go there. So I'll do three weeks there, come home with a modest amount of money, and then I've got a bunch of really good paying things after that in November and December that'll make up for it. So it's always like that.

MR: Do you speak any Spanish?

KP: You know it's funny, I actually learned enough to get by in the countries, and I bone up on it before I go, and then I forget it again afterwards. And I'm learning Swedish now of course.

MR: You say "let's take a break" in eleven different languages.

KP: But, "what time does the next train leave?" No, but I try to learn a little bit of the language. And I like to be in these countries and check out the museums. I love to walk and I've worked out some kind of a discipline plan for my road tours. I listen to a lot of music, I read a lot too, I read all kinds of books, fiction, non-fiction, everything. I just am a very curious kind of person. So that gets me through the tours.

MR: Well you talked about being mostly self-taught as an improviser, and then you mentioned doing school clinics. Do you do things in the schools occasionally?

KP: Yes. I enjoy that. I like teaching and I enjoy being around students. I'm not self taught as a player though, I studied classical quite a bit. So I've had — in fact when I practice now it's mostly that still. And when I go to these schools, one thing I try to bring to the kids is you can't forget that a big part of improvising is forgetting what you know and just using your ear and going on intuition. Because sometimes they get very hung up in the schools

on, if you have this chord you have to play this pattern over it, you know, this is what John Coltrane did when he played this. But the reason why those musicians were famous and why they were so loved is because they were individuals, with their own style and their own sound. And you have to encourage students to explore on their own also. So I tell them it's great to learn all this stuff because any knowledge is good knowledge. But the trick is later to forget that and — it's like things you feed into a computer you know, and then out comes something else. Whatever you read or whatever you live, it all comes into your music. So you can't sit there while you're playing and think about every single chord and what can I play over this, what can I play over this? Because the best moments when you're improvising, you're actually — I hate to say this — but it's almost an out-of-body experience. You can actually listen to yourself playing. You forget about everything. You're just sailing through the changes and saying oh, hey, how did I play that?

MR: And how do I get out of something that I didn't mean to play? Did that ever happen to you?

KP: Yeah. Oh, of course. In fact sometimes you can do that. You play little tricks on yourself. You paint yourself into a corner and then you try to get out of it. But as Dizzy Gillespie said one time, you're only a half step away from salvation at any given moment. Because when you look at a chord and you look at extensions of the chord, you keep adding thirds onto the chord, you have every note in the chromatic scale anyway. So it's all how it comes out at the end, how you resolve a phrase. So to me the object is not to think about every chord as an individual thing, but the whole thing is a big picture. And your object is to get from point A to point B and tell a story and have a flow to it — a beginning, a middle and an end. And getting back to the schools, that's what I try to bring to the students, to show them how they can maybe assimilate all these bits of knowledge they have, and try to find their own way of negotiating these chord changes, not forgetting the knowledge that they have. It's important to learn that stuff but sometimes individuality is not stressed enough.

MR: Well I was going to give you a little blindfold test here, did you ever do one of those?

KP: Great. I love those, yeah.

MR: Well let's see how this one strikes you.

[audio interlude]

KP: Hey, that's me, right?

MR: That's right, good for you.

KP: Actually I never listen to my own records.

MR: Well you should they're pretty good actually.

KP: Why thank you. But if I hear them like this back I'd say hey that's not so bad. That's Howard Alden and myself, a Benny Carter tune called "The Courtship." It's a beautiful song.

MR: A beautiful song.

KP: A beautiful song, yeah.

MR: And I love it too because it just, the approach you took to it seems to match the intent of the tune and it just started — boom — right on the melody. For some reason it just worked really well.

KP: Oh thank you.

MR: And you seem to have a knack for finding tunes maybe that are not played to death.

KP: Well again it comes down to my own boredom threshold. You know George Gershwin is a great composer, but the man wrote hundreds and hundreds of songs. You don't always have to play "Lady Be Good," and "Someone to Watch Over Me." There's all kinds of songs the man wrote. Duke Ellington, Thelonious Monk, there's so much out there. And again, like a song like this, I just try to listen to it and say what can I lend to this song.

MR: Now this section here, it's almost like you guys are both soloing at the same time.

KP: We are. I like to do that a lot. And Howard and I love playing together. We've had a long musical relationship and we've done some duo records. And it's fun because he's not just a rhythm guitarist. He is great in a quintet because he can function as another horn, and I love to do that when I'm using my own musicians, collective improvisation, in a more modern setting like that. It was done years ago in New Orleans jazz, in traditional jazz, so why can't it be done now? The trick is to not fill up every available space and try to listen to each other and be confident enough to leave silence if you feel like, and just play around each other.

MR: Did you ever have the experience where you felt you had to play much, much harder because the rhythm section wasn't good?

KP: Oh yeah. And sometimes it's the wrong thing to do. But you do it because you're panicking and you're trying to overcompensate. Sometimes it's best to try and let yourself relax and just say, as I pointed out before, I'm going to ignore these people and just play for myself. Like if I was playing in a room or if I was rehearsing for Benny Goodman, I'm my own rhythm section, played the changes my own way, and then it really works well. And then you can kind of lift them up sometimes. Occasionally. Not always.

MR: Well I wanted to ask you about "Steppin' with Peps." Most people call you "Peps?"

KP: A lot of people do. Pep, Peps, yeah.

MR: You have one of your own tunes on here, "Huggles," which you, I think you have a sense of humor. You announce one tune here as "one by Benny Aranoff" is that —

KP: Aranoff.

MR: — with his usual sly wit and then your own tune is "Me and My Half Wit."

KP: Oh yeah.

MR: Actually I wanted to ask you how this project, you were born at an early age, really, working on your next project — Caligula, the musical.

KP: Oh yeah.

MR: How's it coming?

KP: I always thought that that was such a strange idea. You know, an all-singing, all-dancing version of Caligula. Two things you would never expect to go together you know. And I've actually had people ask me, seriously, about that. Like are you really working on that?

MR: You could do a double bill with "Annie."

KP: Yes. Annie the Tragedy. The Lost Years. Annie on 42nd Street. No but hey look, you have to have a sense of humor to do this you know. But what was your question anyway?

MR: I don't know if there was a question. I just got a kick out of reading that.

KP: Oh thanks.

MR: I wanted to bring it up.

KP: I actually think about writing some things because I like to do that. And the last record I did I wrote my own liner notes too and I think you would get a kick out of those. And I also am a big fan of the old *New Yorker* humorists, Robert Benchley and S.J. Perelman. I love to read those kind of people. And that's kind of gone now. You don't see that kind of writing anymore.

MR: Have you read any of the things that are written about you?

KP: I can't help reading them. I have learned, it's safe to say, not to let the bad things bother me and not to let the good things go to my head. I just kind of try real hard to not pay too much attention to them. Obviously I love it when I get good reviews. But Sonny Stitt, this is one thing he said to me and it really strikes home now, you know when all is said and done, you have to please yourself. And only you know if you've done what you set out to do a hundred percent and if you're true to yourself and all that. You're the only person. Many, many times I've had what I think are really bad nights and the audience has like gone crazy, and the opposite. I've had horrible nights — I've had great nights and nothing, you could hear crickets in the audience. But you are your own worst critic and the only person that really knows. So the reviewers — I used to get really bothered by bad reviews. And when I did get bad reviews it was always because I play the clarinet and I play older material, it was somebody that was saying that I'm just an imitator or I'm trying to do some retro kind of a thing. And these critics now come up with these weird terms like "neo-bop," "neo-swing," what does this stuff mean? Meantime here I am

innocently just playing music that I like. And I don't think about that stuff at all. In fact I did write to one reviewer because he told me the record that I was influenced by in the review, which I'd never heard before. So I had to point that out to him.

MR: Well someone, I think Scott Yanow, who's a pretty good writer, he said that your tenor mixes Don Byas and Paul Gonzalves.

KP: Yeah. Well see my first inclination is to bristle and say oh how does he know? But it is a compliment and I appreciate that. And those two people, I take that as a compliment because I love both of them. And I guess I could understand where he's coming from because they were an influence on me. I love both of them and I love a softer kind of a tenor sound anyway. I'm not a loud player, I just don't do that. I like Zoot a lot too, Zoot Sims. Lucky Thompson. So that kind of thing, it's like thanks, but again I'm not going to go back to my room thinking oh great, Don Byas and Paul Gonzalves. Because I never feel comfortable if I just rest in one place. I'm trying to just move on. And I don't want to put myself in a box like that. I don't want to say this is what I do.

MR: You've done some recording with Randy Sandke, right?

KP: Yeah.

MR: And some of the stuff I've heard you do with him is very Boppish.

KP: Oh, yeah.

MR: So I wouldn't think that you're — I suppose some of the press you're getting is more that you're, as Scott says, "Ken has helped to keep the tradition of a small group swing alive" in one of the books. But that's not all you're doing.

KP: That's not all I do and I just hate labels like that. Because as somebody gives you a label, even if they're well meaning, that's what you become in everybody's eyes. Or it becomes a jazz fact if it's published in the books. I just hate those kind of things. And if you look back through a lot of interviews with older musicians — Duke always hated that too, or Sonny Stitt hated to be called a Charlie Parker imitator. And I hate to even have to justify what I do, but like the last few records, I did this thing with an orchestra, we did all this twentieth century music, modern classical music. The last one I did with a big band we did this pretty out piece, this concerto that was written for me. And I've played John Coltrane tunes and worked with Tom Harrell. I just consider myself a musician. And I don't think about these labels. In fact I try really hard not to because I don't want to paint myself in the same box as somebody else, even if they're well meaning. Sometimes it can backfire. Especially because I play the clarinet and I like to play songs that may have been written in the first half of this century, people don't even listen to the way you play, they just say Benny Goodman, swing. Sometimes that can work to your advantage, because you can get away with a lot on stage. You can play to an older, more conservative audience and you're playing a Thelonious Monk tune or you throw in a

Coltrane tune, and they've got their eyes closed and they're thinking Benny Goodman swing. So it's fine. It's okay. But I think I tend to bristle any time any label comes up, even if it's well meaning.

MR: Yeah. It's like you want to get the press—

KP: Of course.

MR: But it's always kind of like oooh — did he have to say that?

KP: Yeah. In fact if people ask me now, I did an interview with the *Jazz Times* recently and they said, "what would you call yourself?" I guess the thing that I would call myself is an interpreter of songs, or an interpreter of material. That's what I would call myself. I just try to filter my own personality into whatever music interests me, and that might be anything. In fact I'm trying to get in touch with Elvis Costello right now because I've got a middle person who works with him, to try to see if I can commission him to write something for me. He's doing these classical things now, these chamber works.

MR: Elvis is?

KP: Yeah.

MR: I didn't hear about that, wow.

KP: Yeah. He's been writing pieces for the Brodsky Quartet, the string quartet and that would be kind of interesting if I could get that.

MR: Do you ever get calls for classical dates in New York?

KP: Once in a while, not so much now, because that's a whole closed — I do get calls to do a lot of jingles, ads, I'm on a lot of those, things like that. They use a lot of clarinets on those things.

MR: What was the most silliest sounding jingle you've done? Is that possible to remember?

KP: Well they did, there was a guy — a few years ago they used a Benny Goodman record on a Chase Manhattan bank commercial. And these ad agencies always like to imitate each other. If something is popular they all do it. So then all the clarinet players were getting calls. And they always wanted to do a recreation of "Sing Sing Sing" or something like that. But one guy had me and a drummer come in, and he had taken the old Carnegie Hall record of "Sing Sing Sing" and edited it the way he wanted it. And he wanted us to recreate this edit. But he had no sense of time. So the edit was chopped up so the drums would play like a bar and a half and then the clarinet would come in. It didn't make any sense at all. And this is what he wanted us to play. There was no music written, and this guy was probably getting thousands and thousands of dollars for being the composer of this jingle. And it sounded about as goofy as it sounds from me telling it.

MR: You were able to do what he wanted?

KP: We were able to do it, we took hours in the studio trying to do this. It could have been done so easily.

MR: Right. If he had gotten someone in to just advise him.

KP: Yes. If he actually did his work and wrote something. Instead he plays us a cassette tape of — it was a real backwards way. Because when you do jingles you're supposed to match, they always want to match phrases with if there's an edit or a cut, they want to match it so it fits that. So instead of writing it, he chopped up a tape and that's what he wanted us to do. But we got paid for all those hours we were there. So that's okay.

MR: And do you hear yourself on T.V. occasionally?

KP: Yes I do. There's an American Express one that I did that's played a lot, and Applebee's, which is a chain, I'm on those. That's kind of a fun thing. It's fun to hear myself on the radio once in a while too, on a jazz station. And actually I really honestly, I'm not trying to be falsely modest or anything, but I just don't listen to my own records. It's like watching home movies for me. It's like it's done, time to move on to the next thing, and I hear every mistake and everything I'd want to fix. And when I do my records, I purposely try to not do too much editing or dubbing or anything like that. I really like to leave all the rough edges in there. I think it's real important to have a good feeling over everything being clean and antiseptic. But consequently I hear all the rough edges. But when you put a few years behind it, and all of a sudden you hear something on the radio, you say hey that's really not so bad, that's pretty good. In fact there was one record I did for Hank Jones where I'm playing alto, and I was out in California staying at a friend's house and he plays this record for me, and I didn't even recognize myself. Because I don't play alto that much. And I said hey that guy sounds good, who is that?

MR: Was that "Mr. Gentle Mr. Cool?"

KP: That's the one he did for me, but I did one for him called "Lazy Afternoon."

MR: What a nice gentleman he is.

KP: Oh, great guy, and a genius at the piano, really. A giant. A complete piano player, really.

MR: Well speaking of home movies, thank you for this video, which you got to play with Sweets. What was it like to work with him?

KP: He's a great guy, a really wonderful guy. And again, like I talked about Benny, he still, he's getting up there in years but he still comes out to play, sounds great, he's one of these people that when you hear a few notes you know it's him. He's an individual, he's his own man, and he's a legend. And thank God he's still around and that he'll play with somebody like me. I like him very much.

MR: Just to wrap up, this weekend you'll be playing with some pretty well-known musicians. Has there ever been any awkward moments at these? I know that the promoters, they kind of juggle people, they bring in all individuals, no bands really. And have you ever had a circumstance where the chemistry that they put together just hasn't worked?

KP: Yes that happens sometimes. But thankfully the sets are fairly short. I mean sometimes the promoters — this party actually I've seen the set list, and everything kind of works for this weekend. Because on this one, the musicians put together the sets. Jack Lesberg and Ralph Sutton do the sets. So they know who can play with who. But there were some famous ones a few years ago — I don't know if I should mention names or not — but there was a famous promoter that almost started the jazz parties, and he used to put together the oddest combinations. Like for example I actually was at one where it was Red Rodney and Jay McShann, and things like that. And both of those people are great, but you put two people who have absolutely nothing in common, maybe one or two tunes between them, and that's very awkward. And neither person enjoys it and they just want to get off stage as quickly as possible, with as little bloodshed as they can. But generally these things, you know it's a pretty homogeneous group of musicians and they don't really stretch the boundaries that much in either direction. So it's not set up so there's going to be that many disasters on these. But I've done festivals in Europe where they've put together these alleged all-star groups. A lot of times those don't work because there's all these big egos involved, and everybody is a leader, and a lot of those all-star groups don't work.

MR: Sometimes you wonder, gee, how come this guy never made a record with that guy — because they're all stars.

KP: There's a reason for it. Because they see music differently. They're band leaders, and they don't want to work with that person. And unfortunately, the last person that many promoters ask about the music is the musicians. Part of this thing for them is they want to be a band leader. It's a surrogate thing for them. They can play band leader and put these combinations together. Any time I see the word "all-star" I try to run the other way. Because usually it's going to be a bunch of guys that are not completely happy to be there, and it turns into a pretty good jam session. The music is always better when it's a set band and it's people that work together all the time and play off of each other. I'm always trying to push to get my own group on these things, or play with just people I really love to play with, like Howard and Randy. And we can try to play some new things or actually bring some music up to the bandstand. And the jam sessions are fun too but if you do a lot of them they're not as much fun for us as they are for the audience.

MR: If we were to do an interview in ten years, what kind of things would you like me to be able to say that you've done?

KP: Well we would have finished Caligula — The Musical, then it became a movie. No, I think I'd like to do more orchestra jobs and more things with my own group and I'm moving in this direction anyway now, but just playing more concerts, less of this constant life on the road you know, with this mystery band. So you know that's what I think I

would like to do. Maybe I'll have a book out even, or something like that. More college things too, I love doing those. And I really like to teach people. So ten kids — still on my second wife because I don't want — that's enough now.

MR: Ten kids. You're going to have to play a lot of concerts.

KP: Well wait a minute — I have to be home too a little bit, at least ten days I have to be home.

MR: Right. Well it's been a real pleasure for us.

KP: Likewise.

MR: And on behalf of Hamilton College I want to thank you for your time today, and I hope you have a great weekend.

KP: Thank you. It was very nice talking to you.

MR: All right.